

CASE STUDY · 31 AUGUST 2026

The AI ROI Blind Spot

Why 77 percent of finance organisations now employ artificial intelligence — and only 35 percent can say whether it pays. A classroom case for the Future CFO.

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1. Opening predicament

On 26 August 2026, Protiviti published the results of its 2026 Global Finance Trends Survey under the title *Synchronize*. The headline that should have stopped a capital committee is not the adoption number. It is the proof number. Seventy-seven percent of finance organisations now employ artificial intelligence. AI use in financial forecasting has jumped from 58 percent to 76 percent year over year. Risk assessment sits at 67 percent. Process automation sits at 56 percent. And yet only 35 percent of finance organisations say they are highly or moderately effective at measuring the return on those investments. Fourteen percent deploy AI pursuant to a defined strategy.

Christopher Wright, global leader of Protiviti’s CFO Solutions and Business Performance Improvement practice, framed the shift without romance: finance leaders have moved beyond asking whether to adopt AI. The challenge is to use it to make more informed business decisions and to prove that it is delivering measurable value.

This case asks a single professional question. If you cannot measure the return, on what authority do you approve the next tranche?

2. Teaching purpose

The case is written for MBA, CFA-pathway and mid-career finance leaders inside the FUTURE CFO 2035 classroom. It is designed to do five things.

First, force students to treat survey statistics as evidence, not decoration. Second, separate adoption theatre from a governed operating model. Third, connect AI spend to the two constraints boards will not relax in 2026: cash discipline and data trust. Fourth, give students a reusable capital-allocation frame — S.C.O.R.E. — that survives contact with a hostile audit committee. Fifth, put the student in the chair of a manufacturing CFO who must decide a \$12 million Year-2 programme on Thursday.

3. The fact pattern

3.1 Protiviti 2026 Global Finance Trends Survey

The survey is the primary exhibit. Key published findings, as released on 26 August 2026:

Finding	Why it matters to the CFO
77% of finance organisations now employ AI.	Adoption is no longer scarce. Scarcity has moved to proof and governance.

AI forecasting adoption rose from 58% to 76% year over year.	The function is using models to chew larger data sets and run more scenarios. Speed without a baseline is not value.
Only 35% are highly or moderately effective at measuring AI ROI.	The majority of finance shops cannot defend the next dollar of AI capital with a measured outcome.
Just 14% employ AI pursuant to a defined strategy.	Most deployments are still opportunistic. Boards should treat them as pilots, not platforms.
Security and privacy of data is the top finance priority for a third consecutive year.	Trusted data is the licence to scale. Cyber and lineage sit above the model catalogue.
83% of CFOs rank cash management among their top three priorities amid policy volatility.	Any AI case that cannot name a cash or working-capital effect will lose the budget fight.
Other leading use cases: risk assessment 67%; process automation 56%.	Crowded core. The underbuilt bridge is AI-enabled scenario planning that links forecast, risk and cash.

Table 1. Primary exhibit — Protiviti 2026 Global Finance Trends Survey (press release, 26 August 2026).

Industry emphasis on cash management is not uniform. Financial services 61 percent; manufacturing and distribution 55 percent; healthcare 45 percent; consumer products 41 percent. A manufacturing CFO — the protagonist of the decision challenge below — sits in the second-hottest cohort.

3.2 Corroborating evidence, 2025–2026

Protiviti is consistent with a wider stack. Deloitte’s Q4 2025 CFO Signals survey found that 87 percent of CFOs believe AI will be extremely or very important to how their finance department operates in 2026, yet only 63 percent have deployed solutions. Fifty percent named digital transformation of finance as their single top priority for 2026 — ahead of cash management optimisation and capital allocation. Fifty-four percent named integrating AI agents into finance workflows as a top transformation priority.

Gartner’s Evanta CFO community and 2026 CFO Agenda research placed “executing finance transformation” at number one for a third consecutive year, with AI and automation climbing to number two. Nearly 60 percent of finance leaders planned to raise finance-function AI investment by 10 percent or more.

EY’s Global DNA of the CFO Survey (June 2026) found that only 21 percent of CFOs rate their AI preparedness as leading or advanced. Most still prioritise defensive use cases such as fraud detection and risk assessment; fewer than half apply AI to growth areas such as forecasting or pricing — a contrast worth noting against Protiviti’s forecasting surge, and a reminder that surveys sample different populations.

The Oliver Wyman Forum’s CFO Agenda work reported that only 8 percent of surveyed CFOs have deployed AI-assisted tools or autonomous agents at scale, while 74 percent of key finance activities remain in planning or pilot. Sixty-four percent expect finance to shift away from junior roles; 91 percent expect flat or lower finance headcount.

BCG’s 2026 essay on the AI-first finance function argues that within two to five years leading organisations will operate with agents executing, monitoring and optimising finance activities in real time, with human work moving to exceptions, and with the staff required for today’s workflows potentially falling by half. The CFO’s new design work is the data fabric, the agent ecosystem, and the intervention thresholds.

Intuit executive Ashley Still, speaking to *CFO Dive* in August 2026, predicted that the manual work that consumes half a finance team’s week — reconciliation, exports, error-fixing, report stitching — should be

largely invisible within five years. She described that state not as a differentiator but as table stakes.

4. Analytical frame: S.C.O.R.E.

Students should refuse to discuss “AI strategy” in the abstract. Every proposal in this classroom is run through five gates.

Scope. One workflow. One owner. One baseline. An “enterprise AI platform” that has not yet measured a single process is a procurement event, not a transformation.

Cash link. Name the cash, working-capital or cost-to-serve effect. If the claim is only that the tool “improves insight,” treat the request as a research grant and fund it like one — small, time-boxed, and intellectually honest.

Objectives. Write the decision the model is allowed to influence. If no named decision changes, the model has no business case. A faster slide is not a decision.

Risk and data. Security, lineage, human-in-the-loop thresholds, and an audit trail that internal audit can follow without a vendor in the room. Deloitte notes that 75 percent of organisations plan to deploy agentic AI within two years while only 21 percent have mature governance frameworks. That gap is the CFO’s personal risk.

Evidence. A ninety-day scorecard with cycle time, forecast error, exception rate, hours released, and dollar impact. Kill or scale on evidence. Narrative is what vendors sell. Evidence is what CFOs sign.

5. You are the CFO

You are the chief financial officer of a \$4.8 billion diversified manufacturing group with plants in India, Mexico and the American Midwest. Year-1 AI spend was \$4.1 million. Delivered outputs: a suite of dashboards, a nine-day faster close in two of fourteen legal entities, and a forecasting pilot the FP&A; director describes as “promising.” There is no documented cash impact. Internal audit has written that data lineage from source system to model feature is incomplete. Security and privacy remain the board risk committee’s first agenda item, consistent with the industry pattern.

The CEO and the CHRO want a \$12 million Year-2 programme: an agentic close across all entities, an AI cash-forecasting engine, and an FP&A; copilot rolled out to business-unit controllers. The board pack is due Thursday. You have four options on the table, and you may write a hybrid if you can defend it in one page.

Option A. Approve the \$12 million in full. The argument: speed is strategy; laggards will be priced as analog; Deloitte and Gartner both show the peer set leaning in.

Option B. Approve \$3.5 million only. One workflow, one cash KPI, a ninety-day kill-or-scale gate. Freeze the remainder.

Option C. Refuse new spend. Demand a forensic ROI file on Year-1 before any further capital is released.

Option D. Ring-fence \$2 million for data governance and lineage. Pause model spend until internal audit signs the data fabric.

Required submission: a one-page decision memo. State the option or hybrid. Name the single cash KPI that will sit on the scorecard. Name the kill criterion. Name the human who owns the gate. If you cannot name

those four things, you are not ready to spend the money.

6. Teaching note (for the instructor)

There is no free Option A. Approving \$12 million on incomplete lineage and no cash effect is how finance becomes the last function to learn what operations already knew: activity is not value. Option C is politically clean and strategically late — a forensic file is necessary, but a freeze with no successor design tells the organisation that finance only knows how to say no. Option B without D repeats Year-1: a ninety-day gate on a dirty fabric produces another dashboard and another unprovable claim.

The adult combination is B plus D. Fund one workflow that touches cash — forecast error versus working-capital days, DSO, inventory days, or close-to-cash cycle time. Fund the lineage so audit can follow it. Publish the kill criteria before the spend starts. That is how a 2035 CFO behaves when the survey data says 65 percent of peers cannot measure return and 86 percent do not yet have a strategy.

7. The 2035 implication

By 2035 the CFO who cannot measure AI is not “still transforming.” They are uninsurable. Boards, auditors and eventually lenders will treat an unmeasured model estate the way they once treated an unreconciled bank account: as a control failure with a polite name.

The product of finance will not be the report. It will be a decision with a documented evidence trail — what the model saw, what the human overrode, and what cash moved. Talent will follow that product. The junior seats that existed to stitch packs will thin. The remaining seats will belong to people who can design gates.

Governance is not a policy PDF. Deloitte’s observation that culture is most of governance is the operational truth. A model that books a wrong accrual will not be saved by a framework slide. It will be saved by a human who was trained to stop it, and by a CFO who funded that human before funding the model.

8. Discussion questions

1. Which of Protiviti’s six headline statistics is the most damning for a board, and why?
2. How should a manufacturing CFO translate “83 percent rank cash in the top three” into an AI scorecard that a plant controller will respect?
3. Reconcile EY’s finding that most CFOs still prefer defensive AI use cases with Protiviti’s finding that forecasting is now the lead use case. What does the gap imply about sample, maturity, or fashion?
4. If Oliver Wyman is right that 91 percent of CFOs expect flat or lower finance headcount, what is the ethical obligation of the CFO to the junior bench during the transition?
5. Write the kill criterion you would publish on Monday if you chose B+D on Thursday.

9. Sources

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